ROASTED KABOCHA SQUASH WITH HOT HONEY AND BREAD CRUMBS

SERVES	TOTAL TIME
4-6	**2 h**

INGREDIENTS

228 g	Country bread, torn into pieces
56 g	Olive oil, for the bread crumbs
10 g	Garlic, 2 whole cloves
340 g	Honey
45 g	Calabrian chiles, crushed
7 g	Calabrian chile oil, drained from the jarred chiles
30 g	Unsalted butter, cold and cubed
42 g	Olive oil, for the squash
1.4 to 1.8 kg	Kabocha squash, cut into 2-inch-thick wedges
50 g	Garlic, 10 whole cloves
7 sprigs	Rosemary, for roasting
7 sprigs	Thyme, for roasting
quantity not given	Salt
55 g	Honey vinegar or apple cider vinegar
3 sprigs	Thyme, leaves picked
2 sprigs	Rosemary, leaves picked
2 g	Dried red chile flakes
quantity not given	Flaky sea salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 200°F for the bread crumbs.
2. Spread the torn bread over a sheet pan and bake it 30 to 45 minutes, until dried out with no color on it at all. Crush a shard with the back of a spoon to check, the inside should be dry right through. Let it cool.
3. Pulse the cooled bread in a food processor down to fine crumbs. Stop while they still have some texture rather than going to dust.
4. Set a sauté pan over medium-low heat with the olive oil and the 2 garlic cloves and cook 1 to 2 minutes, until the garlic has perfumed the oil. Fish the cloves out and keep them for another use.
5. Drop the heat to low and line a plate with paper towel. Fry the crumbs in that oil 5 to 8 minutes, stirring now and then, until golden brown, then lift them onto the plate to drain and cool.
6. Set 20 g of crumbs aside. The rest goes into an airtight container somewhere cool and dry and keeps up to 1 week.
7. For the hot honey, stir the honey, crushed chiles and chile oil together in a small bowl. Set 80 g aside. The remainder keeps in an airtight container at room temperature for up to 2 weeks.
8. Raise the oven to 400°F for the squash.
9. Melt the butter gently in a small saucepan over low heat, take it off the heat and stir the olive oil in.
10. Put the squash wedges in a large bowl, pour the butter mixture over and turn them until every side is coated.
11. Lay the wedges skin side down on a sheet pan. Scatter the garlic cloves around and over them, then lay the thyme and rosemary sprigs across the top. Season with salt.
12. Roast about 45 minutes, until the squash is fork-tender and lightly caramelized.
13. Tip the squash into a large bowl, add the vinegar and turn it gently to coat.
14. Spread the wedges out on a large serving platter and drizzle the hot honey over. Finish with the picked thyme and rosemary, the chile flakes, the bread crumbs and flaky sea salt.

NOTES

Honey vinegar is vinegar made from honey, sold online. Apple cider vinegar is the substitute at short notice.
Dry the bread at 200°F with no color on it. The browning happens later in the garlic oil.
Stop pulsing while the crumbs still have texture. They are on the plate for crunch, and dust gives none.
Both the crumbs and the hot honey make far more than this dish needs. The crumbs keep a week in a cool, dry place and the honey two weeks at room temperature.